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RETURN

URC 2026: Diaspora Engagement and Return Support Framework

The Ukraine Recovery Conference 2026 in Gdańsk dedicated a focused session to diaspora engagement strategies and mechanisms to support the return of Ukrainians living abroad. IOM Ukraine facilitated discussions on policy instruments, incentive structures, and community-level integration support needed to convert diaspora presence into active contribution to reconstruction.

3R: Directly anchors the Return pillar: IOM-led multilateral discussion at URC 2026 signals growing institutional momentum for concrete diaspora reactivation policy, moving beyond aspiration to operational frameworks.

IOM UKRAINE

30 Young Diaspora Leaders at URC 2026: 1.5–2M Youth Abroad as Strategic Cohort

Razom for Ukraine facilitated the participation of 30 young Ukrainian leaders from across the EU, Switzerland, and the US at URC 2026, highlighting that between 1.5 and 2 million young

Ukrainians are currently living abroad due to the war. The initiative frames this cohort not as a loss but as a mobilisable asset for Ukraine's future recovery if engaged through structured pathways.

3R: Quantifies the Return opportunity: the 1.5–2M young Ukrainian diaspora is the single largest untapped human capital reserve; structured youth-led engagement at URC 2026 is a leading indicator of policy prioritisation.

RAZOM FOR UKRAINE / FACEBOOK

Prime Minister's Resilience Message at URC 2026 Signals Political Will for Return

Ukraine's Prime Minister used the URC 2026 platform in Gdańsk to deliver a message of national resilience — 'We Fight, We Suffer, We Stay Resilient' — framing diaspora return within a broader narrative of national continuity and reconstruction commitment. The political signalling at the highest executive level reinforces diaspora engagement as a state priority.

3R: Return pillar political enabler: executive-level framing at an international conference elevates diaspora return from a programmatic issue to a sovereign reconstruction imperative, critical for donor and policy alignment.

INSTAGRAM / URC 2026

RECRUIT

Budanov: Ukraine Will Inevitably Need Foreign Specialists to Fill Critical Skill Gaps

Chief of Defence Intelligence Budanov stated publicly that Ukraine will need to recruit foreign specialists, with only just over 11,000 labour migrants currently in Ukraine as of 2026 according to the Association of Recruitment Agencies. The statement acknowledges the depth of human capital depletion from war casualties, mobilisation, and emigration, and signals a policy shift toward opening Ukraine to targeted international talent recruitment.

3R: Core Recruit signal: a senior security official acknowledging the need for foreign specialists is a watershed moment — it legitimises international talent recruitment policy and sets the stage for visa, recognition, and integration frameworks.

KYIV POST

KSE Institute: 213K Active Civilian Vacancies Signal Structural Talent Deficit

KSE Institute's labour market study presented at URC 2026 analysed 213,000 active civilian vacancies as of June 2026, with demand recovering after a January dip linked to seasonal and mobilisation factors. The data reveal persistent sectoral skill shortages critical to reconstruction — in construction, engineering, IT, and healthcare — providing an evidence base for targeted recruitment from diaspora and international sources.

3R: Recruit demand quantification: 213K vacancies provide the empirical foundation for skills-gap mapping and targeted recruitment campaigns — essential for matching diaspora returnee profiles to actual labour

market needs.

KSE INSTITUTE

ILO LEP Mykolaiv & Odesa: Employer-Led Training and Reskilling to Fill Vacancies

The ILO's Local Employment Partnership programme in Mykolaiv and Odesa is delivering demand-driven skilling, upskilling, and reskilling aligned to employer needs, including employer-led training and updates to vocational education curricula. The programme directly addresses recruitment gaps by building a local talent pipeline rather than relying solely on external recruitment.

3R: Recruit supply-side intervention: employer-driven reskilling in two major southern cities creates domestic talent pipelines that reduce dependency on external recruitment and accelerate regional economic recovery.

ILO

RETAIN

ILO LEP4WORK: Kyiv Oblast Employment Partnerships as Retention Anchors

The ILO's LEP4WORK programme supports Local Employment Partnerships across three communities in the Kyiv oblast, creating sustainable job opportunities and reducing push factors for internal displacement and emigration. By stabilising employment ecosystems near the capital, the programme directly contributes to retaining skilled workers who might otherwise seek opportunities abroad.

3R: Retain through local opportunity creation: Kyiv oblast LEPs address the root economic cause of brain drain by creating viable employment alternatives domestically, reducing emigration pressure on Ukraine's most productive workforce segment.

ILO

ILO LEP: Labour Market Recovery Through Social Dialogue and Skills Alignment

The ILO's Local Employment Partnership approach is documented to help Ukrainian communities create jobs, address skills shortages, and build labour market resilience through tripartite social dialogue. By involving employers, workers, and government in co-designing employment solutions, the approach reduces structural unemployment and increases worker attachment to the domestic labour market.

3R: Systemic Retain mechanism: social dialogue-based labour market governance creates the institutional conditions under which skilled workers choose to remain in Ukraine rather than emigrate — addressing retention at its structural roots.

ILO

ILO LEP Case Study: Employer-Led Training as Worker Retention Tool

Documented ILO LEP case studies show that employer-led training and reskilling initiatives — coupled with social dialogue development — increase worker investment in local employment ecosystems. Workers who receive upskilling tied to local employer needs develop stronger retention bonds, reducing the skills-mismatch-driven emigration that compounds Ukraine's brain drain.

3R: Retain through investment: employer-funded upskilling creates bilateral commitment — workers gain localised skills value, employers gain loyalty — a proven micro-level retention mechanism scalable across Ukraine's recovering regions.

ILO

GLOBAL CONTEXT

Ukrainian Immigrant Population in the US: Growth Trajectory Post-2022

Migration Policy Institute data tracked by researcher Jeanne Batalova show that the Ukrainian immigrant population in the United States grew significantly in the immediate aftermath of Russia's 2022 full-scale invasion. The US Ukrainian community represents a high-skilled, geographically dispersed diaspora segment with strong potential for remote contribution and eventual return, requiring tailored engagement strategies distinct from European host-country approaches.

3R: Global context for Return and Recruit: the US Ukrainian diaspora's scale and skill profile creates a transatlantic recruitment and reactivation corridor that URC 2026 stakeholders must map and activate with country-specific programming.

MIGRATION POLICY INSTITUTE
